

61.2 SPECULATION AND DEDUCTION ABOUT THE PAST

"**Must have**" with a past participle is used to speculate about the past when the speaker is sure something happened.

He just disappeared. Aliens **must have taken** him.

Past participle



"**Must**" can be replaced with "may," "might," or "could" when the speaker is not sure whether something happened or not.

They { **might**
may
could } **have taken** him to another planet.



"**Can't**" or "**couldn't**" can be used to refer to something that the speaker is certain did not happen.

It { **can't**
couldn't } **have been** aliens, they don't exist.



FURTHER EXAMPLES



Bethan didn't return my call yesterday. She **must have been** busy.



She **might have** forgotten to call me back.



She **might not have** written down my number correctly.



Paula **can't have** been at the party last night, she was at work.



I didn't see who knocked on the door, but it **may have** been the mailman.



What happened to my vase? The cat **must have** knocked it over.